eyebrows. The city has never hosted a multi-sport international event on this scale. Its largest multi-nation assignment so far—the Asian Aquatics Championships in September 2025—featured about 1,000 athletes. Nor does it command the sporting reputation of states like Odisha, which has emerged as a hockey powerhouse. Ahmedabad's primary sporting calling card remains the Narendra Modi Stadium—the world's largest cricket arena.

Insiders say the decision ultimately turned on economics and strategic geography. Ahmedabad's expanding industrial base and Gujarat's entrepreneurial economy were seen as capable of absorbing the demands of large-scale infrastructure development, already under way as the city formally entered the race to host the 2036 Olympics a year ago. Its proximity to Mumbai—soon to be linked by India's first bullet train—also strengthened its bid.

THE COST QUESTION

The official budget for the Games has yet to be declared, but it is projected at around Rs 5,000 crore. That stands in sharp contrast to Delhi 2010, whose initial estimate of Rs 13,566 crore eventually ballooned to Rs 18,532 crore. In Delhi's case, five new sports venues, an athletes' village of 1,100 apartments and sweeping upgrades to existing facilities consumed the bulk of the funds. "Even core urban works—flyovers, Delhi Metro expansion and airport upgradation—were billed to the Games. This time, none of such expenses will be attributed to the Ahmedabad Games," says Ashwini Kumar, principal secretary, sports, youth & cultural activities, Gujarat. "Urban infrastructure and public transport are being developed for the city's organic growth."

The scale of that parallel build-out is significant. The Sabarmati Riverfront, now 11.5 km long, will be extended to 38.5 km by 2027 and will double as a sporting venue. Currently, Ahmedabad and Gandhinagar together have 5,420 rooms in the three- to five-star segment. About 3,000 additional hotel rooms are planned over the next five years, including 1,500 in the five-star category.

The athletes' village, designed for more than 5,000 athletes and support staff, will be located within a 5–7 km radius. These will largely be studio apartments, rented to working professionals when not in use by athletes, with much of the stock sourced from nearby university campuses. Air connectivity is also being scaled up. In 2024–25, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport handled about 13.4 million passengers. A new integrated terminal slated for completion by 2026 is expected to double capacity.

Only the expenses directly linked to organising the Games will be charged to the event; funding for these costs, Kumar says, is in place. "The cost will be jointly borne by the state and the Centre," he explains. "Broadcast rights, ticket sales, sponsorships and merchandise will recover a substantial part of the expense."

The biggest shift from 2010 lies in

GUJARAT'S ROAD TO THE COMMONWEALTH GAMES

Ahmedabad has already built a steady hosting record in the past few years and a heavy calendar lies ahead

2019 Pro Kabaddi League final; league matches held regularly

2022 National Games, with over 8,000 athletes across 36 disciplines

2023 Cricket World Cup final; three IPL finals since 2022 and other big-ticket fixtures

2025
May-June Ultimate Table Tennis (full season)
August Commonwealth Weightlifting Championships
September Asian Aquatics Championships

2026 Asian Weightlifting Championships

2029 World Police and Fire Games

2030





"THIS MILESTONE REFLECTS INDIA'S GROWING STATURE AS **A GLOBAL SPORTS POWERHOUSE AND REAFFIRMS OUR CAPABILITY** TO HOST WORLD-CLASS MULTI-SPORT EVENTS WITH EXCELLENCE"

HARSH SANGHAVI
Deputy Chief Minister, Gujarat